

Week 7: Setting in Biblical Narrative

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

Where and when a Bible story happens is rarely just backdrop — tonight we'll look at how setting does its own kind of work.

1. Think of a movie or show where the setting alone told you what kind of story you were about to watch — a dark old house, a courtroom, a small town. What settings instantly set your expectations like that?
2. **Read Genesis 3:23-24.** Where does God send Adam and Eve after banishing them from the garden? Keep this direction in mind as we look at a few more passages.
3. **Read Genesis 4:16.** Where does Cain end up after murdering his brother?
4. **Read Genesis 11:1-2.** The builders of Babel migrate "east" to build their city and tower. What do you notice about this repeated direction? What picture is the Bible building in your mind by sending person after person "east"?
5. **Read Genesis 7:12.** How long does the text say Noah and his family endure the rain? What do you think forty has come to represent, and why might the biblical authors keep returning to it?
6. When Jesus' family flees to Egypt to escape Herod in Matthew's Gospel, Egypt — usually the place of slavery and danger in the Old Testament — suddenly becomes the place of safety instead. Why might an author deliberately reverse our expectations about a setting like this?
7. Knowing that biblical writers use place and time this intentionally, how might it change the way you read familiar stories going forward — do you find yourself starting to ask "where is this happening, and what else happened here before?"
8. Is there a "setting" in your own life right now — a season, a place, a kind of waiting — that feels like your own wilderness or your own "forty days"? What do you think might be going on in that timing?

9. As we close, what's one place or time-marker in Scripture that you now want to pay closer attention to the next time you come across it?